Improving Village Life

India's small farmers mostly live in the villages. Their importance for the country cannot be exaggerated. The 'increasing number of small farmers' require 'focus on the measures like development of small farm technology'. 'There is also a need to improve productivity of small and marginal farmers through development and implementation of small holding farm technologies', as the 2021–22 Economic Survey of India notes.

Ratan was seized of its importance nearly two decades ago when he chose to bring foreign technology and processes to help the small farmers. In October 2008, Cornell University was given a $50 million endowment from the Tata Education and Development Trust. Fifty per cent of the grant was allocated to provide a Tata Scholarship Fund for Indian students to study at the university. The remainder was used to set up the Tata-Cornell Initiative in Agriculture and Nutrition.

It aims at improving the 'productivity, sustainability and profitability of India's food system' with a purpose of 'reducing poverty and malnutrition'. It also led to the establishment of the Tata-Cornell Institute for Agriculture and Nutrition (TCI) in 2013 which undertakes research in areas ranging from agriculture, food systems and nutrition to water and sanitation and interventions in 'the complex intersection of agriculture, human nutrition, and poverty'.

The Tata-Cornell Initiative tapped the AguaClara system to improve the supply of clean water and sanitation in India. In 2015, through an Indian NGO, PRADAN, its 'Filtration-Disinfection system was installed in the villages of Gufu and Ronhe' in Jharkhand using a 'lowland sanitary well as the water source'. It was also set up in the 'villages of Jolhakarma and Durgunia' in the same state. These projects have now expanded to new areas and have benefited increasing number of villagers.

Importantly, TCI has also set up a first-of-its-kind database for Farmer Producer Organizations (FPO) with the $1 million grant it received from the Walmart Foundation. This hub brings and analyses data from over 4,000 FPOs to improve the livelihoods of small farmers in India.

To enhance the income of the farming households to improve the quality of life in the villages, 'the Trusts launched the "Mission 2020—Lakhpati Kisan: Smart Villages"' in 2015, through 'Collectives for Integrated Livelihood initiatives (CInL)' in identified states of India. The initiative